

SUPPLEMENTARY SHEET 10

COTTON TO CONSUMER



Corporate Jeans

Industrial cotton is grown on 5% of the world's cultivable land. The production of cotton requires substantial inputs. Cotton crops depend on irrigation and pesticides.

Cotton is grown primarily in the US, India, China, Pakistan and Uzbekistan.

A million cotton producers are killed every year from inhaling the toxic pesticides on cotton plantations.

The production of denim requires large quantities of cotton. Usually, denim mills are located near cotton crops. Denim mills are located primarily in the US with some production in China, the European Union, Brazil and Hong Kong.

Denim uses thousands of tons of synthetic indigo, a major pollutant, to dye denims the shade of blue used in jeans.

Jeans production cannot be automated due to the intricate stitching involved and therefore the jeans industry employs hundreds upon thousands of typically young women to sew millions of pairs of jeans.

Jean's factories are notorious for employing under low wage conditions, in countries such as Guatemala, Bangladesh, or the Philippines, or in immigrant areas of Los Angeles, New York, Toronto, and Sydney.

In 1996, Bangladesh imported 48 Million metres of denim and Turkey imported 85 million metres of denim for the production of jeans.

A small number of large retail chains dominate the textiles industry. These retail giants keep just over half of the final price of jeans. Meanwhile, the hundreds upon thousands of labourers in jeans factories receive 12% of the final retail price.

San Francisco-based Levi Strauss, the first producer of jeans, is now the world's largest clothing manufacturer. Annual sales are worth \$7 billion of which 71% are from the sale of jeans and jean-related items.



Organic Jeans

500 farmers in the village of Koussanar, Senegal grow organic cotton with the help of a local Non-Governmental Organisation.

Cow urine, which contains iron, potassium and magnesium, is used to fertilise the cotton fields. It is also considered to be one of the best insecticides and herbicides for cotton.

It has been found that organic cotton farmers in Senegal have a yield of up to 1.8 tonnes per hectare – almost double the national average.

The price of organic cotton is 30 percent higher than that of conventional cotton.

Textile companies in the North, especially in Europe, are the main processors of organic cotton.

The approaches taken in many organic cotton projects are intended to create a more equitable distribution of benefits, including better returns at the farmer level.

Cotton can grow naturally in most shades of brown and green, eliminating the need for dying altogether.

It is estimated that an organic and sweat-free pair of jeans would cost the consumer \$300. Market research suggests that the consumer is unwilling to pay this price for jeans.

Jeans are produced in factories where unions have been established, allowing employees the right to demand labour rights such as a fair wage and a safe working environment.

The consumer buys jeans made from organic cotton, typically produced under better practices than when conventional cotton is used.